

From Architect to Data Visualization

As a kid growing up in a family of engineers, I loved David Macauley's book, *The Way Things Work*. **Tinkering and sketching** were common in our household, so **studying architecture seemed intuitive**.

It was after my architecture training and work that I **embraced drawing as a delightful, exploratory medium**, a way to build imaginative worlds and invite readers into understanding systems—as opposed to a method for helping clients solving problems or convincing them to build specific things. Shopping in a Berlin bookstore, I realized I could **spark discoveries and encourage engagement with the world's complexity**, all while being paid to **explore and explain with paper, pen, and pixels**.

Cities have always played a role in my education, studying “in them” and about them. **More than making sturdy or beautiful structures, I wanted to understand some of the forces—real estate, resource streams, planning policy—shaping the evolution of cities and their built forms**. That curiosity about contexts got me started on mapping systems and learning computer code so I could work with big, public data on demographics, taxes, and calls requesting or complaining about city services. That **led to my career designing infographics and coding data visualizations**.

My role as an infographic designer **helps people understand processes**; it's particularly sweet when you can help people feel more confident (and safe) navigating and shaping the world around us.

I'm a generalist and have been lucky to work in a lot of different roles: web development, architecture and landscape design, and product and data design. **It can be hard to feel confident as a Jill-of-All-Trades**, especially as a shy, quiet person. But being a generalist gives me a **unique perspective** and helps me identify analogous issues and bridge approaches. Knowing a bit about a lot of things **frees me to constantly ask questions** of clients, collaborators, and peers. Every time I join a new team or start a new project, it helps me feel less shy and gives everyone **permission to be comfortable with uncertainty, learning, and discovery as part of the design process**.

Meg's Journey



Meg Studer

Infographic Designer and Architect

“It's healthy to cultivate random hobbies and obscure skills that bring you joy, friendships, and community.”

